

Chapter 3 Spiraling to Ethnic Conflict: Leaders, Masses, and Nationalism

Abstract

Ethnic conflict is commonly believed to originate from ethnic grievances prevalent among the masses. In this chapter, I argue that state leaders, not ethnic others, are responsible for the outbreak of ethnic conflict. I theorize that when state leaders promote nationalism to legitimize their regime, they frame disfavoured ethnic groups as “enemies within” and marginalize these groups. These groups rebel against the incumbent government to protect their ethnic identity – usually seeking to establish autonomous territory rather than overthrowing the incumbent government. As a result, this struggle spirals into an ethnic conflict. I conduct an empirical analysis using a sample of 157 countries for the years 1945-2007. The results indicate that leader nationalism is, even after reversal causality is considered, a precipitant of ethnic conflict along with territorial and separatist conflict, while mass nationalism is not. Given these findings, the counterinsurgency community should account for the fact that the ascendance of nationalist leaders is likely to destabilize the liberal world order.